

GEORGIA

Particularly great for history lovers, the wine trail through Kakheti dates back 8000 years. From Tbilisi, you can hire a cab and drive to Sighnaghi and Telavi, stopping at family cellars, historic monasteries and qvevri (clay vessels used for winemaking) makers along the way. The routes are as much about Georgian culture, hospitality, and food as they are about wine, and the Caucasus provide a spectacular backdrop.

FRANCE

The country offers some of the easiest wine journeys without a car. From Bordeaux city, Saint-Émilion can be reached by train, followed by a walk through the vineyards. The medieval village is worth exploring, with cobbled streets, restaurants and wine bars. Further north, the Loire combines wine with castles, gardens and rivers, making it as much a cultural as wine trip. Champagne offers a more varied way to explore. Stay in Épernay or Reims and follow the Champagne Route through its villages. And of course, there is always the temptation to linger in the underground cellars with champagne in hand.

And then there is Bordeaux's Médoc Marathon, perhaps the most literal wine trail of them all. The 42.195-kilometre route passes through the vineyards and famous estates of the Médoc, with wine, and food served along the course. Elaborate costumes are part of the tradition too. You certainly don't have to run it to enjoy Médoc, but it is difficult to imagine a more memorable way to travel through wine country.

There are also some wine trails where the landscape is the real attraction. Island wine trails like Santorini, Madeira, Sicily and the Canary Islands all offer unusual landscapes. Some are shaped by volcanic soils, while others combine vineyards with rugged coastlines, mountains and a distinctly island way of life. In Mendoza, Argentina, the landscape is on an entirely different scale, with Malbec vineyards stretching beneath the Andes, making the mountains an essential part of the wine experience.

There are far more wine trails than any one article can cover. The wine may be the reason you set off, but the route is what makes the trip memorable.

NEW ZEALAND

Marlborough's Sauvignon Blanc and Central Otago's Pinot Noir are worth exploring along with a range of adventure sports, all set against spectacular mountain, lakes and vineyard landscapes.

TUSCANY, ITALY

The Chianti Classico route between Florence and Siena winds through vineyards, olive groves, castles and small villages, with Sangiovese at the centre of the wine experience. You can follow the Chiantigiana road, stopping at wineries and local food producers along the way. You can also take hot-air balloon rides that take you above the patchwork of vineyards and hills. ■

Above: A view of Badia a Passignano, a historic village and wine estate in the heart of Tuscany's Chianti Classico region in Italy

PHOTO: GETTY IMAGES